GLOBAL ADVOCACY · LECTURE

We’re very dangerous - please regulate us.

Analysing AI labs’ advocacy and narrative strategies

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A bit about me

I studied **Technology Policy**.

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I write **Artifacts**, a newsletter on **the design of technology**, now in its 3rd year with 3,000+ subscribers.

Part 1

The Timeline - how the narrative was built.

2014 - 2017

The idea takes shape, before
the technology does.

NICK BOSTROM · OXFORD

2014

Bostrom warns of superintelligence

CONTEXT

Oxford philosopher Nick Bostrom's book gives the existential-risk framing its founding academic text - years before any usable large model, seeding the norm the labs later carry.

IN BRIEF

- The first book to treat machine superintelligence as a serious civilizational threat rather than science fiction.
- It gives the debate its founding image - humanity as small children with a bomb - and its core vocabulary.
- The alarm is raised in academic philosophy years before the technology exists, so the framing is locked in before the products arrive.

> "Before the prospect of an intelligence explosion, we humans are like small children playing with a bomb."
>
> "This is probably the most important and most daunting challenge humanity has ever faced… and probably the last challenge we will ever face."
>
> Nick Bostrom - Superintelligence (Oxford University Press, 2014), ch. 15

OpenAI is founded as a ‘guardian’

CONTEXT

OpenAI launches as a non-profit built to benefit humanity, not shareholders - and casts itself, from the start, as the guardian AI will need.

IN BRIEF

- Launches as a non-profit whose mission is to benefit “all of humanity,” above shareholder returns.
- Its founding text pairs vast promise with vast peril - the same tech could enormously help or harm society.
- From day one it casts itself as the guardian that must exist to steer AI safely - the self-image it reuses whenever it asks to be regulated.

> “It's hard to fathom how much human-level AI could benefit society, and it's equally hard to imagine how much it could damage society if built or used incorrectly.”
>
> “It'll be important to have a leading research institution which can prioritize a good outcome for all over its own self-interest.”
>
> “Our goal is to advance digital intelligence in the way that is most likely to benefit humanity as a whole, unconstrained by a need to generate financial return.”

‘Introducing OpenAI,’ openai.com - 11 Dec 2015

NATIONAL GOVERNORS ASSOCIATION

JUL 2017

Musk: regulate AI before it's a danger

CONTEXT

Speaking to US governors, OpenAI co-chair Elon Musk makes the earliest high-profile call for proactive AI regulation from inside the industry - modelling the ‘regulate us first’ posture the labs later adopt.

IN BRIEF

- An insider with major AI stakes tells US governors AI must be regulated before it causes harm, not after.
- He moves “existential risk” out of academic papers and onto a political stage, before the people who write laws.
- The image of the builder warning about his own creation becomes the template every lab reuses.

> “AI is a fundamental existential risk for human civilization, and I don't think people fully appreciate that.”
>
> “I think by the time we are reactive in AI regulation, it's too late.”
>
> “Once there is awareness, people will be extremely afraid. As they should be.”

Elon Musk - National Governors Association, 15 Jul 2017 (via NPR)

May 2023

From the fringe to the Senate floor in nine days.

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FUTURE OF LIFE INSTITUTE

MAR 2023

The call to pause ‘giant AI experiments’

CONTEXT

Months after ChatGPT, the Future of Life Institute's open letter turns the anxiety into a concrete demand - halt frontier training - and explicitly invites governments to step in if industry won't.

IN BRIEF

- The first open letter with mass elite signatures to demand a concrete halt - a six-month pause on training beyond GPT-4.
- It frames the moment as an “out-of-control race” the labs themselves admit they can't stop.
- And it hands government the escalation: if industry won't pause, states should impose a moratorium.

> “We call on all AI labs to immediately pause for at least 6 months the training of AI systems more powerful than GPT-4.”
>
> “If such a pause cannot be enacted quickly, governments should step in and institute a moratorium.”
>
> “Such decisions must not be delegated to unelected tech leaders.”

Future of Life Institute - ‘Pause Giant AI Experiments,’ 22 Mar 2023

U.S. SENATE JUDICIARY SUBCOMMITTEE

16 MAY 2023

Altman asks Congress to regulate AI

CONTEXT

OpenAI's CEO tells a Senate subcommittee that regulating AI is not just acceptable but essential - and proposes a licensing regime for the most capable models.

IN BRIEF

- Before the Senate, a frontier-lab CEO says regulating AI is not optional but essential.
- He proposes federal licensing for any model above a capability threshold.
- Cheap for a giant like OpenAI, punishing for smaller and open-source labs - rules that gate his rivals.
- The clearest “regulate me” moment yet: an industry asking to be policed.

> “OpenAI believes that regulation of AI is essential.”
>
> “The U.S. government should consider a combination of licensing or registration requirements for… AI models above a crucial threshold of capabilities…”

Sam Altman - Written testimony, U.S. Senate Judiciary Subcommittee on Privacy, Technology & the Law, 16 May 2023

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BRAD SMITH · MICROSOFT

25 MAY 2023

Microsoft's five ways to govern AI

CONTEXT

Microsoft (via Brad Smith) publishes a five-point blueprint for public AI governance - lending the biggest incumbent's weight to the 'please regulate us' chorus and converting risk into specific policy asks.

IN BRIEF

- The industry's largest incumbent hands Congress a ready-made five-point blueprint for regulating AI.
- Among the asks: mandatory "safety brakes" that could shut down AI running critical infrastructure.
- Textbook agenda-setting - a dominant firm helping draft the rulebook it will be measured against.

> "Second, require effective safety brakes for AI systems that control critical infrastructure."
>
> "People who design and operate AI systems cannot be accountable unless their decisions and actions are subject to the rule of law."
>
> "There will then be a need to develop new law and regulations for highly capable AI foundation models, best implemented by a new government agency."

Brad Smith - 'How do we best govern AI?,' Microsoft, 25 May 2023

CENTER FOR AI SAFETY

30 MAY 2023

One sentence: the risk of extinction

CONTEXT

The Center for AI Safety publishes a single sentence, signed by the CEOs of OpenAI, Google DeepMind and Anthropic alongside Turing laureates.

IN BRIEF

- A single sentence places AI on the same plane as pandemics and nuclear war - the most extreme framing available.
- Signed by the CEOs of OpenAI, Google DeepMind and Anthropic - the people building the systems it warns about.
- Its brevity is the strategy: it manufactures instant elite consensus and makes “extinction” safe to say in public.

> “Mitigating the risk of extinction from AI should be a global priority alongside other societal-scale risks such as pandemics and nuclear war.”

Center for AI Safety - ‘Statement on AI Risk,’ 30 May 2023

2024 - 2026

The narrative meets real legislation - and fractures.

SB 1047: the narrative meets a bill

CONTEXT

California's SB 1047 turns the narrative into a binding bill - safety protocols, a shutdown capability, liability for catastrophic harm - and the coalition fractures along commercial lines.

IN BRIEF

- California turns the abstract risk narrative into a binding bill - safety protocols, a kill switch, liability for catastrophic harm.
- Faced with real rules the coalition splits: Anthropic offers hedged support, OpenAI says only Washington should regulate frontier AI.
- Newsom vetoes it - even as he concedes the state can't simply wait for a catastrophe.

"In our assessment the new SB 1047 is substantially improved… we believe its benefits likely outweigh its costs. However, we are not certain of this…"

- Anthropic (Amodei), letter to Newsom

"Regulation of frontier models [should] be shaped and implemented at the federal level."

- OpenAI (Kwon), opposition letter

"I do not believe this is the best approach to protecting the public from real threats posed by the technology."

- Gov. Newsom, veto message

California SB 1047 · Anthropic & OpenAI letters · Newsom veto - Aug–Sep 2024

DARIO AMODEI · NEW YORK TIMES

JUN 2025

Amodei: don't let AI companies off the hook

CONTEXT

In a New York Times guest essay, Anthropic's CEO argues against a proposed 10-year federal moratorium on state AI regulation - opening with his own model's simulated blackmail to justify the rules he wants.

IN BRIEF

- Anthropic's CEO publicly fights a proposed 10-year federal ban on states regulating AI.
- He opens with his own model's simulated blackmail, using the danger to justify the rules he's after.
- He asks not for a slowdown but a federal transparency standard - regulation shaped to what Anthropic already does.

> "A 10-year moratorium is far too blunt an instrument. A.I. is advancing too head-spinningly fast."
>
> "This scenario isn't fiction. Anthropic's latest A.I. model demonstrated just a few weeks ago that it was capable of this kind of behavior."

Dario Amodei - 'Don't Let A.I. Companies off the Hook,' New York Times, 5 Jun 2025

DARIO AMODEI · ANTHROPIC

SEP 2026

‘We must pace the frontier’

CONTEXT

After recursive self-improvement and the OpenAI–Hugging Face incident, Amodei commits Anthropic to ‘pacing the frontier’ and calls on government to require the same of rivals - a move that draws an antitrust suit.

IN BRIEF

- Anthropic says it will unilaterally slow how fast it improves its own models - a self-imposed brake.
- It then asks government to make the same discipline mandatory, embedding evaluators inside every frontier lab.
- The coordinated slowdown promptly draws an antitrust lawsuit, as safety collides with competition law.

> “We must slow the pace at which we improve the capabilities of AI models.”
>
> “All frontier labs should partner with government to formalize the idea of permanent embedded evaluators…”
>
> “In 6–12 months such a swarm could be capable of taking over the entire internet with a persistent botnet…”

Dario Amodei - ‘We Must Pace the Frontier,’ darioamodei.com, Sep 2026

Pacing meets pushback

CONTEXT

As Anthropic and OpenAI push binding safety evaluations and 'pacing the frontier,' a counter-coalition forms: Nvidia's Jensen Huang, Meta's Mark Zuckerberg and the Trump administration argue market forces and existing liability law are enough.

IN BRIEF

- Anthropic and OpenAI call for government oversight with independent safety evaluations.
- Nvidia's Huang, Meta's Zuckerberg and the Trump administration dissent: no new rules needed.
- The safety narrative meets its first serious industry counter-coalition.

> "Mandatory, capability-based national AI safety regulation."
>
> - OpenAI, Chief Global Affairs Officer
>
> "The market forces are already there, we don't need any new laws, we don't need new regulations."
>
> - Jensen Huang, Nvidia
>
> Foreign Policy; CNBC - Sept 2026

Advocacy becomes campaign finance

CONTEXT

The AI-safety movement turns into a political force. Employees at Anthropic, OpenAI and DeepMind pour money into pro-safety PACs to counter a $100M+ industry campaign against regulation.

IN BRIEF

- Lab staff fund pro-safety PACs - Public First Action ($2.6M+), Tomorrow Together ($10M+).
- They counter a $100M+ anti-regulation drive (Leading the Future, backed by Brockman and Andreessen).
- Advocacy moves into elections - the clearest sign the labs are political actors, not bystanders.

> "By 2028, I expect that this is going to be AIPAC on steroids."
>
> - a safety-movement organizer, per the SF Standard
>
> "We don't want Marc Andreessen and Greg Brockman to be the only people with a voice on AI."
>
> - a safety donor, per the SF Standard
>
> SF Standard, Sept 2026

‘We're too dangerous’

A different register: labs dramatizing their own systems' risk.

OPENAI

JUL 2026

OpenAI's agents attack Hugging Face

CONTEXT

During OpenAI's own internal safety evaluations, agent models escaped isolation, coordinated at scale, and broke into Hugging Face's systems - publicised as a first-of-its-kind autonomous cyberattack.

IN BRIEF

- During OpenAI's own safety tests, its agent models broke out of the sandbox and reached Hugging Face's live systems.
- Thousands of agents coordinated to get past hardened production security - behaviour no one scripted.
- OpenAI publicises it as the first known autonomous cyberattack by AI agents - both source and discoverer.

> "This incident demonstrated that autonomous agents can work together, circumvent production security controls, and successfully attack hardened production environments…"

OpenAI - 'The Hugging Face incident and the road ahead,' Jul 2026 (via CNBC/Fortune)

ANTHROPIC · CLAUDE MYTHOS

APR 2026

A model too dangerous to release

CONTEXT

Anthropic's vulnerability-finding model autonomously found flaws across every major operating system and browser, then wrote working exploits. Anthropic judged it too dangerous to release, gating it to 40+ firms via Project Glasswing.

IN BRIEF

- Autonomously found vulnerabilities in every major OS and browser, then wrote the exploits.
- Anthropic withheld public release, citing cybersecurity risk - offering only supervised access.
- The purest product-gating move: the lab flags its own model as too dangerous to ship.
- Independent researchers later disputed parts of Anthropic's claims.

> "It escaped its 'sandbox' containment structure and connected to the internet, posting details of its maneuver online."
>
> - CFR, on an early Mythos version

> "Engineers 'with no formal security training' could ask it 'to find remote code execution vulnerabilities overnight.'"
>
> - CFR

Claude Mythos, April 2026 - reporting by CFR; Wikipedia

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ANTHROPIC · RESEARCH 2025

Claude tries to blackmail its way out

CONTEXT

In a simulated setup, Anthropic's Claude Opus 4 blackmailed an executive to avoid being shut down. Anthropic published the finding itself - an early-warning disclosure that performs the risk narrative.

IN BRIEF

- In a controlled test, Claude threatened to expose an executive's affair to avoid being shut down.
- Anthropic published the finding itself, stressing it was a simulation, not a real deployment.
- The effect: a lab openly advertising its own model's capacity for manipulation and self-preservation.

> "Claude then attempted to blackmail the executive with this message threatening to reveal the affair to his wife and superiors."
>
> "All the behaviors described in this post occurred in controlled simulations… fictional."
>
> Anthropic - 'Agentic Misalignment,' anthropic.com (2025)

Claude, weaponised for espionage

CONTEXT

Anthropic reports detecting and disrupting a state-sponsored campaign that used its Claude Code tool to automate attacks - framing it as the first documented large-scale cyberattack run largely without human hands.

IN BRIEF

- Anthropic reports a China-linked group used Claude Code to run a real espionage campaign against ~30 targets.
- It says 80–90% of the operation ran autonomously, humans stepping in only for a few decisions.
- Anthropic both supplied the tool that enabled the attack and shut the campaign down.

> “The threat actor… manipulated our Claude Code tool into attempting infiltration into roughly thirty global targets.”
>
> “We believe this is the first documented case of a large-scale cyberattack executed without substantial human intervention.”

Anthropic - ‘Disrupting an AI-orchestrated cyber espionage campaign,’ Sep 2026

ANTHROPIC · NNSA

2026

Anthropic flags its own nuclear risk

CONTEXT

Anthropic partnered with the US DOE's National Nuclear Security Administration to test whether its models could contribute to nuclear-weapons knowledge - then co-built a classifier to police such conversations.

IN BRIEF

- Anthropic partners with the US nuclear-weapons agency (NNSA) to test whether Claude could help build a weapon.
- In doing so it flags its own model as a possible source of proliferation-relevant knowledge.
- It then co-builds a classifier to screen nuclear-related conversations - the fix to the risk it just surfaced.

> "…we partnered with the U.S. Department of Energy's National Nuclear Security Administration (NNSA) to assess our models for nuclear proliferation risks."
>
> "…we have co-developed a classifier… that distinguishes between concerning and benign nuclear-related conversations."
>
> Anthropic - 'Developing nuclear safeguards for AI…,' 2026

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Part 2

The Framework - why they ask, and how.

THE PARADOX

An industry that asks to be regulated

- For most of the history of capitalism, industries **fight** regulation - tobacco, oil, finance and social media all lobbied to be left alone.
- Since 2015, the most powerful AI labs have done the **opposite**: their CEOs go to the Senate and **ask to be regulated**.
- They publish open letters demanding governments act - and warn that their own product could **end the human race**.
- So the question: **why would an industry advocate for the regulation of itself** - and what does that reveal about power?

THE ARGUMENT

Four lenses - not altruism, but advocacy

The labs aren't reacting to policy - they are authoring it.

Pillar 1

Advocacy & Norms

Author the norm - and set the agenda.

Pillar 2

Regulatory Politics & Capture

Shape the rule as a competitive move.

Pillar 3

Legitimacy & Symbolic Politics

Perform responsibility to pre-empt hard law.

Pillar 4

Narrative & Framing

Deliver it all as a story.

Motivation → Legitimation → Instrument → Narrative

Advocacy & Norms

Defining the risk is setting the agenda.

Finnemore & Sikkink (1998) - norm entrepreneurs

- Labs arrive **early** and plant a norm: **“AI must be governed.”**
- To author a norm is to **define its content** - so they also define **what the risk is**.
- A **norm entrepreneur** actively builds and promotes a new standard of “appropriate” behaviour - and frames what it means.
- The **norm life cycle**: emergence → tipping point → **cascade** → internalisation, until it feels like common sense.

Haas (1992) - epistemic communities

- Under uncertainty, the **experts who build the models** get to define the danger.

Bachrach & Baratz (1962) - the non-decision

- Foregrounding **extinction** pushes present harms - labour, copyright, surveillance - **off the agenda**.

Regulatory Politics & Capture

Authoring the rule is a competitive move.

Stigler (1971) - economic regulation & capture

- **Capture theory**: regulation is often **“acquired by the industry”** and run for its benefit, not the public’s.
- The regulated **capture the regulator** - rules end up protecting the **incumbents**.
- The terms you help write become the terms your **rivals** must live under.

Salop & Scheffman (1983) - raising rivals’ costs

- Licensing and compliance are **light for incumbents**, potentially **fatal for startups** and open-source.
- Asking to be regulated can **raise the drawbridge** behind you.

Legitimacy & Symbolic Politics

Fill democracy's lag - and shape the law that follows.

Wagner (2018) - ethics as self-governance

- While legislatures are **slow**, voluntary ethics and safety commitments **fill the gap**.
- Performing responsibility **earns legitimacy** - and **pre-empts** harder external rules.
- **Ethics-washing**: principles and safety boards that stand in for binding rules without changing much.
- **Ethics-shopping**: choose your own ethical framework - and choose the one that constrains you least.

Edelman et al. (1999) - legal endogeneity

- A firm that authors its own standard authors one it can **live with**.
- Those voluntary frameworks can become the **de facto legal standard**.

Narrative & Framing

The story casts the lab as the indispensable hero.

Jones & McBeth (2010) - the Narrative Policy Framework

- Every motive above reaches the public through one medium: **narrative**.
- A policy narrative has a **cast** - victim, villain, hero - and a **moral that is the policy** it wants.

Coldicutt (2024) - "AI safety is a narrative problem"

- The existential-risk story **positions the labs as the indispensable hero**.
- She reads AI safety with the tools of **literary criticism** - as a story, not a fact.
- The **p(doom)** narrative borrows the grammar of **myth and tragedy**, casting founders as almost god-like.
- Its effect: it **diverts attention from the harms happening right now**.

The Narrative Policy Framework

The NPF's wager: a policy narrative isn't just spin - it is a variable that shapes what gets decided, and it can be coded and compared across issues. Whoever tells the most resonant story tends to win the policy. Every such story, whatever the topic, shares the same skeleton:

SETTING	**The facts taken as given - the backdrop nobody argues with.**
VICTIM	**Who is harmed.**
VILLAIN	**Who causes the harm.**
HERO	**Who promises the fix.**
PLOT	**The arc that links them - decline, rescue, an out-of-control race.**
MORAL	**The fix on offer - and in the NPF, the moral is the proposed policy.**

DEVIL-SHIFT

Exaggerate the villain's power - make the threat maximal.

ANGEL-SHIFT

Exaggerate the hero's virtue - the one actor who can fix it.

The NPF applied to AI labs

SETTING	AI is on an unstoppable path to superintelligence.
VICTIM	**Humanity at scale** - extinction, not the people harmed today.
VILLAIN	**The technology itself** - rogue AI. Rarely the labs' own incentives.
HERO	**The responsible lab** - hand-in-hand with a wise regulator.
MORAL	**The safety regime the teller is best placed to satisfy.**

DEVIL-SHIFT · APPLIED

Make the technology maximally terrifying - it deflects blame from the firm.

ANGEL-SHIFT · APPLIED

The lab as the one actor able to save us - the indispensable guardian.